

What we do recall is that we went to see the local attorney we had used to set up the deal, who explained why it wasn't her fault. And when asked if we could contest the matter, she replied with something like, "The law is pretty clear on this point. You're supposed to pay."

We did.

Later, when we got to know people better, we realized that we had been fools. Lawyers in France—and other countries—typically give one kind of advice to Americans and another to their local clients. And when we described the transaction to an accountant a few years later, he looked horrified. Of the tax bill, he inquired in disbelief and amazement:

"You did what with it?"

"Well, we paid it. . . ."

"You paid it? You're not supposed to do that. The tax people must have been shocked. They were just negotiating with you. They didn't expect you to pay it."

The French tax system looks a lot like the U.S. system—on paper. The same concepts are there. Many of the same numbers, too. But the way it works is quite different. It is Anglo-Saxon—or perhaps European business school—on the outside. On the inside, it is Latin. It may appear clear and unambiguous, but there is always room for discussion.

Besides, most tax matters are not criminal. They are like disputes between a house owner and a plumber—or a man and his tailor. There is plenty of bluff and bluster on both sides and an inevitable settlement. Neither the taxpayer nor the tax collector is bound to tell the truth. Neither is particularly shocked or offended when he discovers the other is lying to him. And neither takes the tax law completely seriously.

Americans naively value "the truth" and "the law" much more than most foreigners. They also have some residual respect for the government. These are weaknesses in the American character that will probably be corrected in the years ahead. But readers should be aware that their own instincts and training are not always well suited to the circumstances in which they live.

There isn't anything especially uplifting or noble about submitting to governmental authority. Instead, treat it as it deserves to be treated—sometimes a protector, often a predator. It may be a sin to lie to your